of the battle and can still be read in the script and language in which it was first composed.

Why did Ashoka choose to immortalize the gory details of war? The victorious king tells a tale of death and decimation entirely against himself, damning his actions in the very hour of what every conquering general of that period in history, regardless of country, context, and culture, would have proclaimed as a triumph. This is not just rare, it is astonishing enough to seem bewildering. A long litany of kings after Ashoka got their military accomplishments eulogized in dramatic verse and prose. Kharavela of Kalinga (*c*. first century BCE), even while recording donations to the Jaina community, describes at length how various contemporary rulers—the Rathikas and Bhojakas, the Yavana king Dimi(ta) and the king of Magadha Bahasatimita—were forced into submission by him.[22] In much the same way, Rudradaman's second century CE account of the repair of a dam in Junagadh simultaneously sketches in some detail all the various territories, ranging from Sindhu-Sauvira to Saurashtra and Aparanta, that he valorously gained.[23] Ashoka's utter uniqueness is that the one and only account that he caused to be recorded of a successful war is one in which the conventions of state propaganda are turned on their head. The triumph is recorded as a disaster. Defeat is snatched from the jaws of victory. A chronicle of imperial misfortune is concocted in defiance of the established practice *of all preceding time*. The emperor weeps when he ought to swagger. This reversal of the most hoary narrative tradition of conquest is now so well known that we hardly see it any longer for what in essence it was, and remains: a staggering reversal of the very conception of kingship. The compassionate and caring king is born and proclaims himself, as H.G. Wells recognized, for the first time in world history. Ashoka's amazing contrition also signals the beginning of a different phase of his rule, a phase in which the historian enters the comfort zones of hard evidence.